

Eyewitness Trap Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 15-20 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	15-20 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	eyewitness-trap

Big idea: Memory is reconstructive, not photographic.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Eyewitness Trap Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A short silent hallway scene with one misleading follow-up question. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Eyewitness Trap Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A confidence-versus-accuracy table for memory claims. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Memory is reconstructive, not photographic.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Eyewitness Trap Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	When should memory be trusted as evidence?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text.
- A short silent hallway scene with one misleading follow-up question.
- A confidence-versus-accuracy table for memory claims.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

Activity Steps

1. Show a busy image for 10 seconds.
2. Remove it and ask factual questions: colours, objects, positions, text, number of people.
3. Ask students to rate their confidence in each answer.
4. Reveal the image and compare accuracy with confidence.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: When should memory be trusted as evidence?
- Why can sincere testimony still be unreliable?
- How might leading questions change remembered knowledge?

Knowledge Questions

- When should memory be trusted as evidence?
- Why can sincere testimony still be unreliable?
- How might leading questions change remembered knowledge?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a busy classroom image followed by questions about colours, positions, and text. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...